

answer is simple. I am myself, not them. I have to use my own comparative advantages. I'm not as shrewd a judge of people as my father and I'm not the genius Buffett is.

It is important to use this book to learn, but don't use this book to be like Warren Buffett. You can't be Warren Buffett and, if you try, you will suffer. Use this book to understand Buffett's ideas and then take those ideas and integrate them into your own approach to investing. It is only from your own ideas that you create greatness. The insights in this book are useful only when you ingest them into your own persona rather than trying to twist your persona to fit the insights. (A twisted persona is a lousy investor unless you're twisted naturally.) Regardless, I guarantee that you cannot be Warren Buffett no matter what you read or how hard you try. You have to be yourself.

That is the greatest lesson I got from my father, a truly great teacher at many levels—not to be him or anyone else, but to be the best I could evolve into, never quitting the evolution. The greatest lesson you can glean from Warren Buffett? To learn from him without desiring to be like him. If you're a young reader, the greatest investment lesson is to find who you really are. If you're an older reader, the greatest lesson is that you really are much younger than you think you are and you should act that way—a rare gift. Were that not possible, then Mr. Buffett wouldn't still be ably evolving at what for most people is postretirement age. Think of Warren Buffett as a teacher, not a role model, and think of this book as the single best explanation of his teachings, well stated and easily learned. You can learn an enormous amount from this book, and that can be the foundation for developing your own successful investment philosophy.

Kenneth L. Fisher

July 2013